KAMPOT THROUGH TIME

A Free Self-Guided Heritage Walk

Theme: French Colonial-Era Architecture in Kampot, Cambodia

1. The Idea

Project Background

Kampot is a historic town in southern Cambodia known for its riverside setting, old commercial streets, and surviving historic buildings. Its urban landscape reflects different periods of development, including French colonial-era architecture, Chinese commercial influences, and later changes in how buildings are used. Some historic buildings now operate as hotels, shops, cafés, and other businesses. However, visitors may not know the stories behind these buildings, their architectural features, or how their uses have changed over time. Historical information is also spread across different websites, publications, and archival sources.

A digital walking guide can bring this information together in one place. By combining historical research, photography, and digital storytelling, the project can make Kampot's architectural heritage easier to discover and understand.

Project Concept

Kampot Through Time is a free, mobile-friendly website that helps international tourists and Cambodian residents explore Kampot's historic streets and learn about selected heritage buildings through a self-guided walking experience.

Instead of joining a guided tour, visitors can explore at their own pace using an interactive map, short historical stories, current and archival photographs, and optional audio guides. Each location will introduce the building's history, architectural characteristics, former uses, and changes over time, where reliable information is available.

The proposed walk begins at Durian Roundabout, continues through five other selected locations, and ends at Entanou Bridge. Visitors can learn about the buildings along the way and enjoy the riverside views at the final stop. The route will be checked on foot to confirm convenient connections between locations.

Target users

- **Primary audience:** International tourists visiting Kampot who want to explore independently and learn about the town's history.

- **Secondary audience:** Cambodian residents, students, and people interested in architecture, local history, and cultural heritage.

Devices

- **Mobile phones:** The main device for viewing the map, reading stories, checking directions, and listening to audio guides while walking.
- **Laptops and tablets:** For researching the locations, viewing historical photographs, and planning a visit in advance.

2. Website Pages

- **Home:** Introduces the project and its purpose, features a photograph of Kampot's historic architecture, and includes a "Start the Walk" button and route preview.
- **Walking Map:** Displays all six locations in order, with map markers and directions to help visitors move between stops.
- **Place Details:** Provides each location's historical background, architectural features, current and archival photographs, audio guide, sources, and visitor information.
- **About & Sources:** Explains the project's purpose and approach, and lists the books, websites, archival materials, and other references used.

3. Main Functions

- **Interactive Walking Map:** Shows all six locations and the proposed route. Visitors can select a map marker to open the corresponding place details.
- **Historical Stories:** Presents short, easy-to-understand descriptions of each location, including its past use, architectural features, and changes over time.
- **Audio Guides:** Offers one- to two-minute recordings that visitors can listen to while exploring. Written transcripts will also be available.
- **Photo Gallery:** Shows present-day buildings alongside archival photographs where available, helping visitors compare the past with the present.
- **Visitor Information:** Provides directions, approximate walking times, and access information, including whether a building can be viewed from the street or requires permission to enter.

4. Content and Data

Each location will have a name, map position, historical background, architectural details, photographs, and an audio-guide script. The content will be based on research and presented in clear language for visitors without specialist knowledge.

Selected locations

1. Durian Roundabout

Role: Starting point

Durian Roundabout is a recognizable landmark representing Kampot's association with durian production. Its distinctive sculpture provides an introduction to the town's local identity and agricultural heritage.

- **Story focus:** How the durian became a symbol of Kampot.
- **Source:** Evendo — Durian Roundabout

2. Hotel Old Cinema (Former 7 Makara Cinema)

Role: Cinema history and architectural reuse

The building was reportedly first used as a Chinese theatre known as *The Gong*, later becoming 7 Makara Cinema. After a period of decline, it was restored and reopened as Hotel Old Cinema in 2019. Its yellow and turquoise façade retains distinctive Art Deco features.

- **Story focus:** From theatre and cinema to boutique hotel,
- **Sources:** Wander-Lush · Leighton Travels

3. Historic Shophouses Around Old Market Street

Role: Commercial history and architecture

Kampot's historic quarter contains old shophouses reflecting the town's commercial development and mixed architectural influences. Details such as balconies, shutters, doors, and façades provide clues to how these buildings were designed and used.

- **Story focus:** How historic streets connect architecture, trade, and everyday life.
- **Source:** Kampot Old Quarter Walking Guide

4. Former Kampot Fish Market / Starbucks Building

Role: Market history and adaptive reuse

The former fish market is described in local heritage guides as a historic market building dating to the 1930s. Its later commercial reuse offers an opportunity to examine how Kampot's older buildings adapt to changing needs while retaining elements of their original character.

- **Story focus:** From traditional market to contemporary commercial space.
- **Source:** Kampot Old Quarter Walking Guide

5. Entanou Bridge (Old French Bridge)

Role: Final stop and riverside landmark

Entanou Bridge is a prominent landmark spanning the Preaek Tuek Chhu River. Built during the French colonial period, it is associated with the development of transport connections around Kampot. Its structure and subsequent changes offer a way to explore the town's infrastructure and history.

Sources: Wander-Lush — Things to Do in Kampot · IntoCambodia — Kampot Province

Content and research materials

- Historical descriptions and architectural observations.
- Current photographs taken during field visits.
- Archival photographs and historical maps where available.
- Audio-guide scripts and recordings.
- Map locations, walking directions, and visitor information.
- Source references and image credits.

Sources: Academic publications, historical records, archival collections, reliable heritage articles, official websites, and field observations. Building dates, former uses, and other historical claims will be checked against reliable sources. Image credits and permissions will also be considered before publication.

5. Look and Language

- **Languages:** English for Version 1, with Khmer as a possible future addition.
- **Colours:** Warm cream, dark navy, white, and muted grey.
- **Visual style:** Minimal, clear, and mobile-friendly, with large building photographs, short historical stories, archival images, and a simple map.
- **Media and communication approach:** Use historical research, photography, written storytelling, and audio to communicate heritage in an engaging way.
- **Design inspiration:** A heritage or museum website that combines strong photography with clear navigation and accessible historical information.
- **Design priority:** Make the website easy to navigate while walking, with readable text, clear map markers, consistent place pages, and simple audio controls.

To keep the project manageable, the first version will focus on the essential self-guided walking experience.

The following features will be excluded:

- User accounts, registration, and personal profiles.
- Online payments, bookings, or paid-tour comparisons.

- Live traffic information.
- User reviews, comments, and chat.
- Advanced route optimization or automatic itinerary generation.
- A complete digital archive of every historic building in Kampot.
- A full Khmer-language website and multilingual audio library.

Version 1 will concentrate on six selected locations, a practical walking route, researched historical stories, photographs, and optional English audio guides. The website will be free to use and will not require visitors to register.

Project Goal

Kampot Through Time aims to use media and communication to make Kampot's architectural heritage more accessible. By combining historical research, visual documentation, and digital storytelling, the website will help visitors discover the stories behind historic buildings while exploring the town independently.